

MEETING POINTS

Three reasons why Hasina's visit can make a difference

TERROR

Bangladesh was becoming a hotbed of terrorism. Hasina has taken action against terror groups targeting India.

BORDER DISPUTES

The border had become a flashpoint; the two countries have agreed to work out a final agreement soon.

TRADE

India provides trade concessions, gives \$1 billion line of credit to Bangladesh to develop infrastructure. Provides it transit access to Nepal and Bhutan.

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during Hasina's visit on Mutual Legal Criminal Matters, Transfer of Sentenced Persons and the agreement on Combating International Terrorism, Organised Crime and Illicit Drug Trafficking, are an indication on how the two countries have engaged in cooperating against the scourge of terrorism. For India, this step will go a long way in ensuring that terror fugitives can no longer find safe haven in Bangladesh and the activities of Indian insurgent groups like ULFA and terror groups like Lashkar-e-Toiba can be checked.

Hasina's visit has written a fresh chapter in Indo-Bangladesh ties. It is a welcome change from the previous regime of Khaleda—which had a hawkish view on India—a time when the country had become a hotbed of terrorism. The Indian leadership thanked Hasina for her role in clamping down on the terror groups in Bangladesh and for quietly helping India by deporting some of its wanted fugitives—a move a senior intelligence official describes as “unprecedented”. As a reciprocal gesture, India will also be handing over about 20 fugitives wanted in Bangladesh.

The personal chemistry between Manmohan and Hasina was visible during their discussions. “There is little to sort out. You have sorted out most of the problems in your comments,” she told the prime minister. At the Indira Gandhi Award ceremony, held at the Rashtrapati Bhavan, she touched a personal chord when she talked about the traditional links between her family and the Indian leadership. “It was an instant meeting of minds when she met the Indian leaders,” remarked Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao.

While terrorism emanating from Bangladesh may decline, the hope is that cooperation in combating terror may only intensify following her visit, as the two countries have also developed an umbrella of agreements. While India extended a special welcome to Hasina, there are vital stakes to ensure the stability of the

current Government, given that the Congress and the Awami League have had traditional ties which were visible when Hasina's entire family met Congress President Sonia Gandhi to to rekindle old ties. For India, the importance of Hasina also stems from the fact that the country had been on the brink of Talibanisation and she presents a visible hope as a moderate leader of Bangladesh, and New Delhi needs to support her.

Thus the decision to allow Bangladesh to transit to Bhutan and Nepal through India is also aimed at giving her some room to manoeuvre. Besides, New Delhi has also sought to silence the vested lobby in Bangladesh that had been accusing Hasina of a sell-out. “It is a win-win relationship and Hasina's visit is a turning point in Indo-Bangladesh relations,” says Veena Sikri, former Indian high commissioner to Bangladesh.

India wanted to demonstrate that it will go more than a mile and addressed Dhaka's concerns over issues such as water resources. Manmohan assured Hasina that New Delhi will not do anything on the Tipaimukh Dam that would adversely affect Dhaka's interest. The dam, to be built on the Barak river in Manipur, has created a political storm in Dhaka. New Delhi is also looking favourably at Dhaka's request for infrastructure development including building bridges and flyovers in capital Dhaka, which will become a visible symbol of Indo-Bangladesh friendship.

But even as the two sides pick the threads of the visit, New Delhi would also have to help Hasina fight the extremist elements within and outside Bangladesh. There could be fresh attempts to eliminate her due to her attempts at cracking down on the Islamists. Besides, the fundamentalists and Pakistan-backed parties are worried as some of their key leaders are being tried for war crimes committed in 1971. While Hasina's visit scores an A on deliverables, the key would be the implementation of the ambitious agenda because this a historic opportunity to fix ties that both countries cannot afford to miss. ■

the two countries where we would be sensitive to each other's concerns.”

Besides, a cordial relationship is crucial for India to neutralise Pakistan's influence in Bangladesh. And even though South Block may not admit it publicly, growing Chinese influence in the eastern neighbourhood has become a cause of concern. China helped Bangladesh modernise its Chittagong port with many Chinese companies being active in the country. It also makes good economic sense as improved ties would mean greater access for Indian companies to the untapped Bangladeshi market. For Bangladesh, it would mean better employment and economic benefits.

The three agreements signed